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Research Paper :

Truth and Reconciliation Commissions in Northern Europe

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Introduction

Norway (2018), Finland (2021) and Sweden (2021) have all established Truth and Reconciliation Commissions (TRC), inspired by earlier processes, particularly the Canadian model. Excluding Russia, which remains largely inactive in this area, Northern Europe has recently witnessed the emergence of state-led reconciliation initiatives addressing historical injustices committed against the Indigenous Sámi peoples (appendix 1). As the Indigenous majority group in the region (count for about 80 000 individuals with half of them in Norway), and the only Indigenous people recognized in the EU territory, the Sámi peoples have experienced a long settler-colonial history, exposed to forced assimilation, discrimination and prejudice from the majority society.

If, over the years, the Sámi peoples have achieved increased cultural recognition, including the establishment of Sámi Parliaments in the 1990s, they continue to lake of formal ownership and effective control over their traditional lands. Their political voice and rights remains limited, particularly in cases where state economic interests prevail. The Fosen Case in Norway illustrates this dynamic, as the state forcibly built wind farms near and within Sámi grazing lands despite strong opposition, endangering their traditional livelihoods and cultural survival.

This paradox raises a central question : do reconciliation processes in Northern Europe truly repair historical harm, or do they primarily serve to protect state authority and legitimacy ? This paper argues that reconciliation with Indigenous peoples in the Northern Europe represents the final stage of the state's assimilation project. Rather than constituting a rupture with colonial policies, they function as their modern extension, characterized by the aim to preserve political stability and reinforce settler-state sovereignty.

Literature Review

A) Theories

The assimilation policies of the Nordic states, commonly known as "Norwegianization", "Swedification", and "Finnicization", have long since been formally abolished and substantial efforts have been made to restore both political and cultural rights. Nevertheless, strong feelings persist in many communities. These feelings arise from the enduring impacts of these assimilation policies, which manifest, through racism against the

Sámi and the national minority groups, as well as the ongoing infringement upon their traditional ways of life and rights.

This study will go through two main theories. For the first one, the settler-colonial theory, it is important to distinguish settler-colonialism and classical colonialism. The latest signifies a relation of external domination by a minority over a native majority population, governed from a distant imperial center, which is not the case in Northern Europe, since Indigenous Sámi peoples are minorities. On the other hand, settler colonialism is informed and driven by sustained "logic elimination" that seeks to remove Indigenous peoples to gain access to their territories. It is characterized by the progressive disappearance in a variety of ways (extermination, expulsion, incarceration containment and assimilation) of Indigenous peoples. Settler colonialism is also defined by its persistent goal to naturalize its ongoing existence, seeking to challenge the meaningful existence of Indigenous life and locate colonial dominances in the past. This theory continue to influence the analysis of colonial studies today, especially in the field of critical Indigenous studies. With this definition, it is clear that settler colonialism is a structure characterizing Sápmi (the Sámi territory), both in the past and present. In the past, Sámi families owned their territories they used for hunting, fishing and reindeer herding. However, from the moment silver and other mining interests has been discovered, they were dispossessed of their traditional lands. Their system was slowly eradicated from the 18th century.

Therefore, it leads us to the second theory : the politics of recognition. Indeed, these politics are a type of interaction between social struggles and the State, in which the main issue is the official acknowledgment of a group's existence as a minority within the society. In Northern Europe, the governments politically recognized Sámi rights, leading to the creation of Sámi Parliaments to acknowledge them as a minority in the society and promote their interests, based on the reparation of historical wrongs.

Sámi leadership considers the reconciliation process as a way to improve the state-Sámi relations, and empower and strengthen Sámi society. The people agrees that there is a need to identify and discuss the historical and present wrongs by the state, including the history of assimilation, dispossession of land and resources, legacy of residential schools, language and identity theft, forced conversion to Christianity, and many others. However, there is this shared sentiment that the Sámi experience of colonialism is almost entirely unknows to Nordic states population. Today, the governments' intentions of reconciliation are still ambivalent, as Indigenous rights are being weakened by initiatives such as logging, mining, mass tourism and

infrastructure plans. As a result, Sámi wonders how they can trust the state as a party to reconciliation while for the past several years, it has been backtracking on Sámi rights. One of the most know critique of this theory was proposed by Charles Taylor. He rejects the colonial politics of recognition, arguing that for Indigenous peoples, seeking recognition from the state would be a “dead end”.

B) Key concepts

Starting from these two theories, four concepts are essential to define. The first one Is the concept of reconciliation. It represents the process of restoring social cohesion in societies damaged by conflicts, as well as investing in local and national capacities to heal past wrongs. In the Northern Europe context, reconciliation passes through the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions, tasked with discovering past wrongs in the hope of resolving conflicts with Sámi peoples, left over from the past.

Then comes the assimilation, the process by which a minority group or culture comes to look like and adopt the behaviors values and beliefs of the dominant or majority group within the society. This process can lead to the loss of a minority group’s language, traditions and cultural practices over multiple generations. The most important is that assimilation can be a graduate or a forced process, with the latter often occurring through government policies.

It also includes the concept of state legitimacy. By definition, a state is legitimate when citizens accept its right to rule over them. This legitimacy matters because without it, there is likely to be conflict and disorder, since all states need a degree of legitimacy to govern effectively. It became an essential point in political science studies, allowing to understand rises and falls of states, as well as the ruling of some peoples over others.

Finally, the Sámi sovereignty refers to the collective right of the Sámi people to exercise authority over their lands, cultures, political institutions, and ways of life. It is independent of the states that govern Sápmi, or in shared partnership with them. This sovereignty is grounded in their status as an Indigenous people, their pre-state presence in the region, as well as international norms such as UNDRIP (United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples).

C) Literature Review

Many researchers have studied the link between reconciliation and assimilation in settler-colonial societies.

Critical analyses of reconciliation argue that those processes often confuse recognition with justice, thus perpetuating colonial power. It is called “tools of subjugation” (Victoria Ceratto, Reconciliation or Colonial Continuity ?), enabling colonial powers to define terms, limit Indigenous sovereignty and ensure that power remains in their own hands. Victoria Ceratto also see reconciliation efforts as a “colonial continuity”. Rather than a break with the past, powers adapt assimilation to modern political needs. In the same idea, Bruce Mclvor (Reconciliation as a Massive Failure | Bruce McIvor) considers reconciliation as a failure “because it rests on a foundation of system racism”.

On the other hand, others consider reconciliation as a process of symbolic and material repair, based on mutual respect and political considerations (Reconciliation In Settler-Colonial States: A Study Of The Political Apology - The Yale Review Of International Studies).

Recent research takes more a middle but critical position. Michael McCrossan (Reconsiderations of Reconciliation and Recognition | Acadiensis) see that discourses of reconciliation and recognition reproduce settler-colonial power, by integrating Indigenous peoples into the state system. He also considers that reconciliation reconfigures domination, rather than eliminating it.

In the same ambivalent point of view, the Yale Review of International Studies argues that political apologies rely on acknowledgement, inclusion and symbolic rupture, highlighting how reconciliation prioritize symbolic gestures over structural changes. However, it states that the effect of settler-colonial policies persists long after the end of assimilation. Therefore, symbolic reconciliation is both necessary and insufficient.

In Northern Europe, Truth and Reconciliation Commissions have recently been implemented in Norway, Finland and Sweden. However, Russia is lagging behind with attempts being made to silence critical Indigenous voices.

In this article (2024), the author acknowledge the historical persecution of rights to culture and language, as well as the new threats posed by climate change and land exploitation to the existence of Sámi communities. However, Truth commissions processes, suggested by the Sámi Parliament across Northern Europe, are considered as a great hope for the Indigenous people.

In other studies, led by the Danish Institute for International Studies, the main question stays to know if these reconciliations processes have a chance to work, or even to occur. As Norway

finally sat-up its Truth and Reconciliation Commission, we can observe that, in nearly five years, the subject has remained rarely presented to the population.

In most of the articles, the necessity of those Truth and Reconciliation Commissions and the possibility to engage an examination of colonialist policies is discussed. They situate these processes in "a global context concerned with transitional justice, truth commissions and indigenous rights" (Elin Skaar, 2025). At the same time, they are wondering why, what and how, keeping with rational questions.

I finally found an article highlighting the risk of a continuation of colonialism in the reconciliation process because of the pushing for extensive land use and development plans, detrimental to the interest of the Sámi. It demonstrates that the Finnish state actively engages a logic of elimination towards the Sámi, concluding that the Indigenous peoples may be reconciled into a contemporary injustice.

D) Gaps in literature

Many scholars point issues with how reconciliation is often superficially treated and how colonial norms still exist. In the Nordic context, the excessive use of lands, which is disturbing Indigenous' farming and life, is sometimes used as a proof of contemporary colonialism.

However, fewer studies explicitly conceptualize reconciliation as a distinct and evolving stage within assimilation politics. Even though many authors discuss the limits of reconciliation or the way it has been guided by state interests, they rarely frame reconciliation as not just a repetition of earlier colonial practices, but a more sophistical and adaptative strategy designed to preserve state stability. Besides, there is a lack of comparative research exploring how different settler-colonial states construct reconciliation, particularly in the context of Northern Europe, which has received significantly less scholarly attention than North America.

Research Hypothesis

Building on this gap in the literature, this research proposes the hypothesis that reconciliation in Northern Europe does not represent a break with assimilation, but rather its transformation and culmination. Instead of abandoning colonial logics, states reinterpret assimilation through the language of healing, multiculturalism, and national unity, allowing them to respond to

demands of Indigenous peoples while maintaining control over territory, resources, and political authority.

This approach also assumes that reconciliation processes arise less from a genuine state commitment to repairing historical injustices, than from sustained Indigenous mobilization and pressure. In this sense, reconciliation functions as a state strategy aimed at managing dissent, reinforcing legitimacy and ensuring political stability, while leaving the structural foundations of settler sovereignty largely intact.

Methodology

This research uses several complementary qualitative approaches. First, it analyze discourses, policies, meanings and narratives, which is characteristic of a qualitative research. The data includes scholar studies on Sámi communities, governmental documents, Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) reports, political speeches, and interviews or statements produced by Sámi institutions.

Within qualitative research, it relies on three methodological research. The first one, the explanatory research, seeks to identify social, economic, political or cultural causes behind a phenomenon. In this case, it helps explain why reconciliation often reproduces assimilation, and why states tend to adopt symbolic rather than structural reforms. The interpretive research comes in second. It aims to understand subjective meanings and lived experiences. Because this analysis focuses on governmental statements, Truth and Reconciliation Commissions' rhetoric, political discourses and symbolic gestures, it is perfect to understand these complex and evolving phenomenon that are colonization, assimilation, legitimacy and reconciliation. Finally, the last one is the critical research, emphasizing power structures, domination, and the reproduction of inequality. This approach is closely aligned with settler colonial theory, critical Indigenous studies, and critiques of recognition, and therefore helps reveal how state-led reconciliation may reinforce existing hierarchies.

Besides qualitative research, this research is also empirical, as it examines real-world material rather than relying only on theory. It studies what Northern European governments have actually done, what the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions' reports conclude and how states talk about reconciliation. Data, like indicators of land loss, language decline, or socio-economic disparities, are also used to contextualize the analysis.

Finally, this research aims to identify causal mechanisms through interpretive analysis. Indeed, it seek to understand why state-led reconciliation works the way it does. The working hypothesis is that reconciliation processes are influenced by the state's interest in maintaining stability and legitimacy. This allows us to examine how reconciliation can operate as a continuation of assimilation by managing dissent rather than by transforming the relationships between the state and Indigenous peoples.

In this idea, Northern Europe is a really interesting region, especially because of its internal contradictions. Indeed, Nordic countries are widely seen as global leaders in human rights, yet they still run assimilation policies towards Indigenous peoples. The differences between the three countries (Norway, Sweden, Finland) are also engaging, providing opportunities for a comparative analysis, as each state has adopted distinct approaches to Sámi rights and reconciliation. In addition, the reconciliation processes in Northern Europe are relatively recent and still ongoing, which gives a contemporary relevance to this study. Finally, while the academic literature on reconciliation is heavily concentrated on Canada, research on the Nordic context remains limited. This study therefore contributes to filling an important gap.

Data analysis

A) Sámi Truth and Reconciliation Commissions (Appendix 2)

In recent years, national truth commissions, tasked with documenting violations committed against Indigenous peoples, have been established in the Nordic countries : Norway (established in 2018), Finland (established in October 2021), and Sweden (which announced a commission in 2021). Their purpose is to address unresolved political and historical issues, document injustices, and create conditions for reconciliation. In theory, these processes aim to repair harms through recognition, historical clarification, and, in some cases, proposals for reparations. In these cases, reconciliation is mainly presented as a process of recognition and dialogue, rather than as a mechanism for redistributing political authority or territorial control.

Norway has the most advanced process. Its Commission is mandated by the Parliament, which must respond to the final report, and conducted extensive consultations with Sámi representatives. The three tasks of the Norwegian TRC are :

1. "Perform a historical survey to map the Norwegian authorities' policy and activities towards the Sámi and Kvens/Norwegian Finns locally, regionally and nationally.

2. Carry out an investigation of the effects of the Norwegianisation policy. The Commission is to consider how the Norwegianisation policy has affected the majority population's attitudes to the Sámi and Kvens/Norwegian Finns, and will investigate the consequences of Norwegianisation up until the present day.
3. Propose measures to contribute to further reconciliation."

The report notes that the Sámi benefit from stronger institutional protections such as the Sámi Parliament and constitutional recognition, compared to the Kven, Norwegian Finns, and Forest Finns, who are classified as national minorities without a representative democratic body. The Commission proposes measures to strengthen Sámi and minority cultures and recommends legal revisions, including equal protection for minority heritage sites and updates to naming laws to address identity loss caused by Norwegianization policies. However, these recommendations remain largely focused on cultural and symbolic restitution, while issues of land ownership and resource control are not directly addressed.

Finland's Truth and Reconciliation Commission was created through cooperation between the state, the Sámi Parliament, and the Skolt Sámi Siida Council. Sweden followed by establishing its own commission, although with a more limited mandate. Both aim to investigate the historical and ongoing discrimination suffered by Sámi communities since the colonization of Sápmi, emphasizing the need to protect Sámi language, culture, and traditional livelihoods, which remain strongly connected to land and water. The Swedish process has a more limited scope compared to Norway and Finland, which already suggests an uneven political commitment to reconciliation in the region.

B) <u>Scope and nature of reconciliation recommendations</u>

1. Findings of the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions

Although the work of the three TRCs was indeed launched, only two have submitted their final report on the situation of the Sámi. Indeed, Sweden has still not released its report, two years after the one concerning the Tornedalians, Kvens, and Lantalaiset came out.

In recent years, there have been some debates about whether the concept of colonialism can be applied to describe the relations between Norwegians and the Sámi in the modern era.

In the Norwegian led report, stories quoted give insight into the grievances caused by direct assimilation policies and conflicts between groups in Norwegian society. It also highlights the

frustrations related to neglect by the authorities and the feeling of having to constantly fight for the right to belong to another ethnic group.

The report emphasizes that, during the Norwegianization of the newly created state, minorities were sometimes treated differently from the majority within the framework of post-war welfare state policies. It also identifies ongoing processes of indirect assimilation in the areas of language, health, culture, as well as the continued threat to traditional livelihoods and commercial activities, including in particular reindeer herding by the Sámi.

A major finding of the report is the large knowledge gap, meaning the majority population mostly have no knowledge, or only limited knowledge about the Indigenous and national minorities' language, culture, and history. This knowledge gap is a direct factor in the failure of secured rights implementation.

In Finland, the final report has finally been revealed at the beginning of December 2025 by the Finish TRC. It revealed that more than 400 Sámi interviewed for the report described restrictions, particularly in boarding schools, on the use of their own language and the practice of their culture. Indeed, today, out of the eleven historically attested Sámi languages, only 9 are still spoken. Furthermore, the United Nations published in January 2011 a report urging the governments of Sweden, Finland and Norway to increase their funding for efforts to safeguard Sámi languages. The Finish TRC's report also revealed that Finland used Sámi lands for its own economic interests and that the community, which relies on agriculture and livestock for its livelihood and may not be fluent in Finnish, was unable to defend its rights.

2. *Recommendations propositions*

To respond to these weaknesses, the TRCs have issued recommendations.

In Finland, the report, recently published at the beginning of December, revealed several proposals such as increasing the resources of the Sámi Parliament, establishing a Nordic Convention on the Sámi to ensure cross-border cooperation among the Sámi peoples, as well as a law requiring state authorities to cooperate and negotiate with the Sámi on any measures likely to affect them. These proposals involve significant recognition and protection of the Sámi people's rights. In addition, regarding traditional livelihoods, the report recommends the creation of a separate government for Sámi reindeer herding and the recognition of their fishing rights. However, given that this report is very recent, it is extremely difficult to predict whether

the government will follow these proposals. Moreover, among these measures, none truly protect Sámi lands, preferring to encourage dialogue and negotiations with state authorities.

Norway is the only country that has gone beyond offering official apologies and symbolic reparations. Indeed, in 2001, the Norwegian Parliament established the "*Samefolkets Fond*" (The Sámi People's Fund). This fund provided collective economic compensation to the Sámi for the cultural and linguistic harm suffered due to the Norwegianization policy.

However, among the 17 resolutions adopted by Norway's Parliament in response to the TRC's report, none directly address the loss of lands. Indeed, they only emphasize knowledge-building, apologies, revitalization of language and discrimination. State narratives consistently frame reconciliation as a process of healing, unity and mutual understanding, rather than as a redistribution of political authority or territorial control.

In Sweden, although the final report has not yet been released, improvement proposals have already been put forward by Mr. Fabián Salvioli, UN Special Rapporteur on the promotion of truth, justice, reparation, and guarantees of non-recurrence. Among them are measures to return cultural heritage and skeletal remains belonging to the Sámi people, official apologies from the Church of Sweden in October 2021, as well as access to psychological support to heal the traumas of past violence (like for all other citizens). These measures are, however, rare in terms of repairing the harm inflicted on the Sámi during the 19th and 20th centuries. Similarly, the Act on Consultation on Issues Concerning the Sámi People obliges the government to consult Sámi representatives before adopting a decision that could have a direct impact on the people. However, the act does not ensure that the Sámi viewpoint is taken into consideration in decision-making, given that their free, prior, and informed consent (FPIC) is not required.

Finally, none of the commissions challenge state ownership of land or require Indigenous consent for extractive projects.

C) <u>Limits, concerns and ongoing challenges</u>

1. Structural inequalities in Nordic reconciliation

Across all three countries, concerns have emerged regarding the composition of the commissions, the scope of their mandates, and the political willingness to implement their future recommendations. A well-known problem with truth commissions applies here : reports are often published, acknowledged, and then forgotten. Their impact is weakened by the lack of follow-up mechanisms, limited dissemination to the public, and the fact that their conclusions

are rarely integrated into national education systems. Yet, revising historical narratives is essential for meaningful reparation and for guaranteeing non-repetition.

A report from the Danish Institute for International Studies revealed that Indigenous peoples and national minorities still struggle to have their rights respected in Norway. Indeed, although the final report of Norway's Truth and Reconciliation Commission was publicly read and broadcast live for 35 hours, the TRC rarely made national news over a five-year period of work. This situation highlights one of the general issues emphasized in the TRC report, namely the lack of knowledge about the history and current conditions of the Sámi.

At the same time, Sámi people in northern Europe face socio-economic disparities rooted in historical assimilation policies, as well as persistent cultural marginalization, despite material equality in the Nordic states. Although these countries are among the most established democracies in the world, characterized by high levels of egalitarianism, public health research shows that experiences of ethnic discrimination are still common among the Sámi. This suggests that the Sámi continue to face social inequalities. In Norway, 8.3% of non-Sámi respondents and 14.9% of Sámi respondents reported having experienced discrimination. In Sweden, these figures are 15.1% and 25.4%, respectively. As a result, it is difficult to justify that in the Nordic welfare states, which create equal opportunities for all their citizens by reducing economic inequalities and promoting social mobility, about one in four Sámi would be a victim of discrimination.

Indeed, social structures continue to create inequalities for the Sámi in the Nordic welfare states. The limited cultural and political independence, the rights granted to the Sámi, as well as various decolonial efforts, have not been able to put an end to discrimination. Structural inequalities maintain the status quo, where the Sámi lack self-determination, and even less so the political and economic power necessary to make the structural changes needed, often based on policies that require government organizations.

2. Resource Exploitation and the Limits of Reconciliation

If green transition has become a guiding principle for policies and a solution to the multiple environmental crises facing the world, the term has become ambiguous, encompassing policies on fossil-free steel production, increased mining for critical minerals, the development of renewable energy production, and commercial forestry. These solutions are geographically dependent on the northern parts of Norway, Sweden, and Finland, in Sámi territory. Such activities can have significant negative impacts on Sámi lands as well as traditional livelihoods,

like reindeer herding, already threatened by previous infringements on their land and by climate change.

In 2010, the Norwegian Water Resources and Energy Directorate (NVE), issued four licences for wind farms on the Fosen peninsula, including in Storheia and Roan (appendix 3). However, the portion of land concerned is near or within the territories of the Sámi people. The project threatens to destroy grazing lands and compromise traditional herding practices. Indeed, when wind turbines are in place, reindeers avoid the areas entirely, becoming unusable. Despite strong opposition from the Sámi communities, the construction was completed in 2020.

The justification is even harder to accept as Sámi peoples are told that this is about green energy and future, “But at what cost, and to whom ?” asks Ellinor Gutorm Utsi, member of the Sámi community. According to a study, 85% of the region’s pastures are affected by at least one land-use pressure. A 2016 report estimated that in the last 60 years, Sweden had suffered a 71% decline in its lichen-rich forests, which provide essential food for reindeer during winter. Besides, the climate is rapidly changing. The Sámi are on the frontlines, as the Arctic is warming nearly four times faster than the rest of the planet. This affects how the reindeer graze and migrate, while unusually hot summers leads to a proliferation of parasitic insects, spreading disease among herds. This is why reindeer herder Anders Kråik, a Sámi member of a working group, declared : "If the Truth Commission project only serves to shed light on history, it makes no sense to us […]. We need to strengthen our rights and give the Sámi influence over decisions on Sámi lands, instead of being told to go to court if there are disputes”.

In 2016, the Sámi Parliament published a report on mental health of the Sámi, at a time when the number of suicides among young reindeer herders was high, as they felt like they had no future and saw their land eaten away by industries. Many Swedes consider their country to belong to a single people, one culture, one history, one language. But it is not the case for the Sámis. They are an Indigenous people who benefit from this international status, the only Indigenous people in the European Union

Discussion

Recently, the Arctic began to be treated as a “geopolitical hotspot” and as a “resource frontier”. One of the main drivers of these dynamics is the increased knowledge of the resource located in Arctic seas and lands. This has triggered numerous economic development projects in the region, in order to make the commercial exploitation of such resources viable. However, critics

argue that it represents a typical neo-extractivist mode of development and capital accumulation, and that it requires new instruments and technologies to control land, territory and resources, which could harm and displace the Indigenous populations of the Arctic living in the affected areas.

In Northern Europe, these policies coexist with reconciliation initiatives aimed at the Sámi. States promote reconciliation and offer apologies without the necessary transfer of power. This reconciliation allows them to demonstrate their compliance with international norms without altering national power structures.

These debates generally ignore Indigenous political projects, institutions and structures in the region. They erases the colonial violence underlying the relation between Arctic States and Arctic Indigenous peoples. The Deatnu Agreement, for example, transformed one of the finest salmon rivers in Europe, located in the heart of Sápmi, into an international boundary in 1751. Since then, salmon fishing in the Deatnu River has been regulated by bilateral agreements negotiated between Norway and Finland (the most recent in 2017), in spite of a very strong and uniform opposition of the Sámi.

Therefore, politics of recognition led by Northern Europe states remain largely ineffective. They are widely criticized for offering symbolic inclusion to Sámi people while leaving the fundamental structures of material and political domination intact. Concerns are rising in Sweden especially, as specific reindeer areas have not been officially demarcated in the country, despite the recognition of the principle that Sámi traditional land use and occupation can give rise to property rights. At the time, in Finland, 90% of the land located in the area designated as Sámi homeland is legally state-owned land. Studies recognize the need to increase the autonomy and self-governance power of Sámi Parliaments, as well as to strengthen their ability to participate in decision-making in matters that affect Sámi people within the Nordic countries.

This patterns has been describes as the “fragmentation of Sápmi”, whereby Finland, Norway, and Sweden pursue limited reconciliation with Sámi through truth commissions, apologies, and cultural measures while maintaining state control over land, borders, and extractive projects. In this perspective, Nordic reconciliation is less about redistributing power, and more about integrating Sámi grievances into a narrative of human and democratic states that can acknowledge wrongs while continuing current territorial and economic arrangements.

At the same time, it is important to acknowledge the significance of the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions themselves. Their establishment followed long-standing demands

from Sámi Parliaments and represents an important opportunity to document historical injustices, give a voice to Indigenous experiences, and challenge dominant national narratives. As these processes are still ongoing, it remains difficult to assess their long-term impact or to rule out the possibility of future positive developments. Nevertheless, current evidence suggests that reconciliation has so far remained largely symbolic, with limited structural consequences.

One of the major obstacle to meaningful change remains the risk of majority complacency, where minorities stay outside the conscience of the majority population. Research have already shown that high democratic rates is not a guarantee for recognized and confident minorities. Nordic states often present themselves as human rights leaders, an image that reinforces their legitimacy internationally and nationally. Yet, Sámi communities continue to denounce discrimination, human rights violations and persistent marginalization, in particular regarding land ownership and access to traditional territories.

This contradiction is intensified by what Sámi people call “green colonialism”. Indeed, the sustainable ambitions of the Nordic countries push them to develop green infrastructures near or within Sámi homelands, pushing them even far away through the North. While framed as environmentally progressive, these projects restrict grazing areas, disrupt traditional ways of life and deepen existing patterns of dispossession.

Overall, the failure of the Nordic states to fully take into account the past and present impacts of colonial and assimilationist practices and policies towards the Sámi sustains structural inequalities. Even though assimilation policies have been officially abolished, their effects persist through racism, limited self-determination and continued control over land and resources. Sámi experiences of colonialism remain ignored by the Nordic states and not well-known among the majority population. As a result, colonial processes are deeply rooted and exist as part of social structures in the Nordic states.

Finally, Sámi representatives have made clear that their goal of securing relations among their people across borders and promoting the self- determination of the Sámi people as a whole is not based on a desire to form a separate Sámi State. This stance challenges the assumption that national borders are the sole markers of political organization and authority, highlighting the possibility of alternative arrangements that respect Indigenous autonomy while maintaining state unity.

Conclusion

This research paper examined whether reconciliation processes, concerning the Sámi in Northern Europe, constitute a true break with past assimilation policies or rather represent their modern extension. By focusing on Truth and Reconciliation Commissions in Norway, Sweden, and Finland, the study sought to determine whether these processes primarily aimed to redress historical injustices or served to protect state authority and political stability. The analysis showed that, in the Nordic context, reconciliation works essentially as a symbolic process of recognition rather than as a redistribution of political power or territorial control.

Using settler colonialism theory and critical approaches to recognition, this paper situates reconciliation within a broader historical continuum of assimilation. Existing scholarship has highlighted how recognition can coexist with persistent structures of domination, and this research contributes to this understanding by applying these perspectives to the Nordic Sámi context. While reconciliation is often presented as progressive, it can also reproduce colonial power relations when disconnected from any material and political change.

The empirical analysis of the Nordic Truth and Reconciliation Commissions revealed significant similarities among the three countries. While the commissions differ in scope and institutional weight, they share a common interest in historical clarification, dialogue, and cultural recognition. However, key issues such as land ownership, resource control, and decision-making power remain largely under state control. Besides, ongoing extraction and "ecological transition" projects in Sámi territories illustrate how reconciliation happens alongside persistent territorial and economic pressures. These findings support the hypothesis that reconciliation is less a break with assimilation than a modern reformulation, adapted to contemporary norms of human rights and democratic legitimacy.

This research also acknowledges the importance of the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions, particularly because they were established in response to demands from Sámi political institutions. Because many of these processes are still ongoing, it remains difficult to assess their long-term effects and their potential for significant transformation. Future research will be needed to determine if the recommendations of these commissions are being implemented, as well as if reconciliation can move beyond symbolic recognition to structural change.

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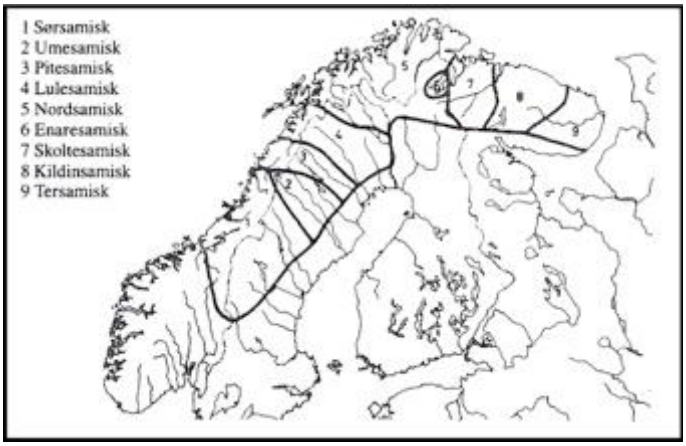
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Appendix

Appendix 1 : Location of different Sámi peoples in Northern Europe



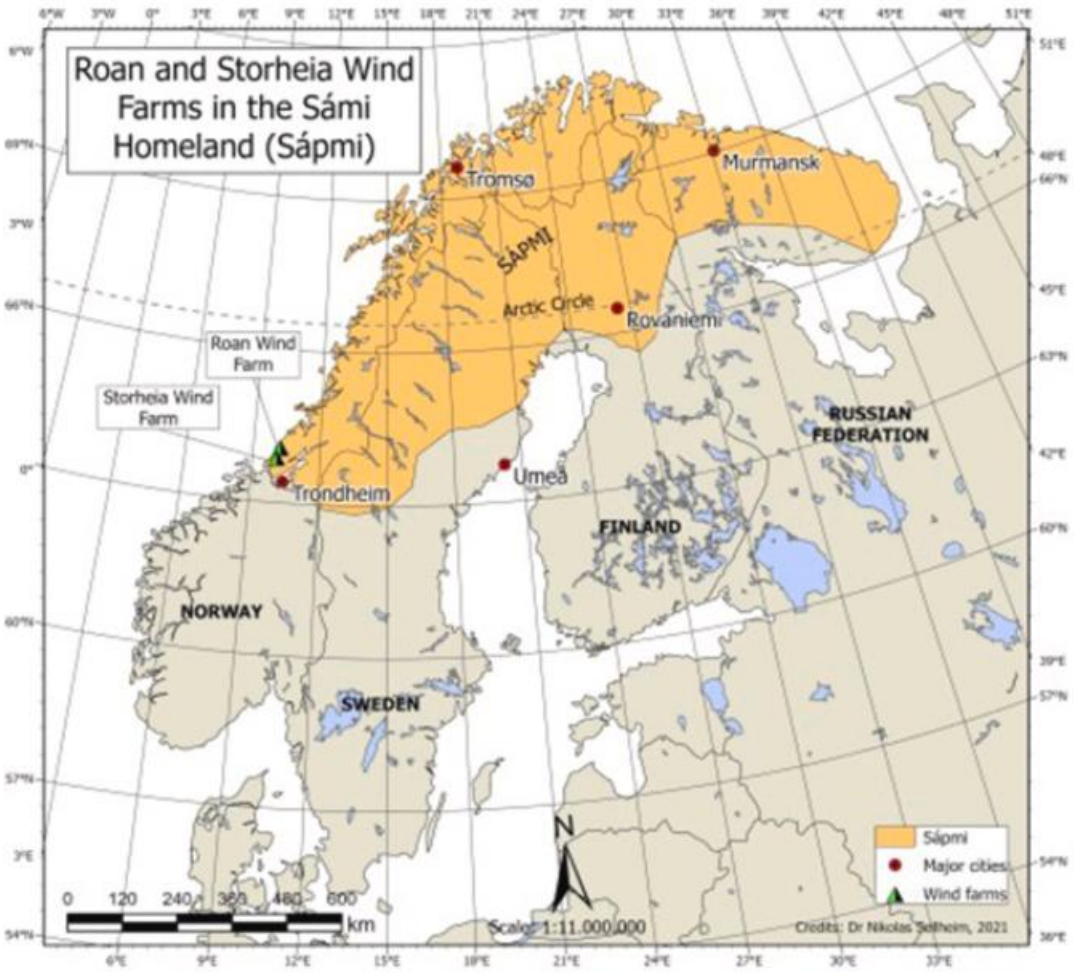
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Appendix 2 : Rights recognition and reparations for assimilation policies directed at the Sámi and national minorities in the Nordic countries, Elin Skaar

Reparations	Norway	Sweden	Finland
Sámi nationally recognized as Indigenous people	1990	1977	1995
Status of Sámi rights	Constitutional	Constitutional	Constitutional
Ratification of ILO convention	1990	Not ratified	Not ratified
Sámi Parliament	1989	1993	1995
Sámi recognized as official language	Yes	Minority language	Minority language
Official apology to the Sámi	Yes 1997 (the King)	Yes November 24, 2021 (The Church of Sweden)	No Plans for The Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland to apologize
Economic compensation to the Sámi	2000	NA	NA
Samefolkets dag (Feb 6) institutionalized	1993	1993	1993
Kvens recognized as national minority	1998	1999	—
Kven language officially recognized	2005	1999	—

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Appendix 3 : Roan and Storheia winf farms in the Sámi homeland



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